



review

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Sucker Punch is a studio best known for their Sly Cooper series on the PlayStation 2. After much success with their first IP, they've now turned their attention towards something more rooted in reality, but barely. InFamous is a superhero sandbox action game exclusively for the PlayStation 3. In it, you play Cole McGrath, a messenger in the fictional Empire City. A package assigned to Cole causes a massive explosion that rips through half the city, and mysteriously endows him with electrical powers. Soon after the explosion, the city descends into chaos and is run over by gangs. A plague outbreak then forces the government to barricade Empire City's residents in, leaving them to fend for themselves.

The game is essentially Cole's quest to get to the bottom of what happened to the city and how he was granted his special electrical powers. The story is told in the form of 2D comic book style

cutscenes, which work surprisingly well with the game. The two key gameplay components in InFamous are Cole's electrical powers and the morality aspect. Empire City is an open sandbox and Cole's new-found abilities also make him stronger and more agile, allowing him to make big jumps and easily negotiate platforming sections.

At the start of the game, Cole has limited electrical powers, which he is able to use in multiple ways. He cannot carry any weapons, so his melee attacks and electrical powers are all he has to fight the bad guys, or good guys, depending on how you play it. You can either zap individuals by shooting electricity at them or send an electrical shockwave through the ground, which will cause greater damage. You can also perform a similar, but more powerful shockwave when landing from a jump.

inFAMOUS

There are more electrical powers that will be unlocked as you progress through the game, and you can even upgrade existing attacks to make them more powerful.

In case you're wondering, Cole has no other special powers besides zapping his enemies. And you can't carry weapons either so Cole is pretty much a one-trick pony. Cole's electrical powers aren't limitless, so every now and then you will need to recharge him. This can be done by sucking the juice out of electrically powered objects such as lamp posts, phone booths and moving cars. Recharging Cole's powers is also a great way to prevent him from dying when he takes too much damage.

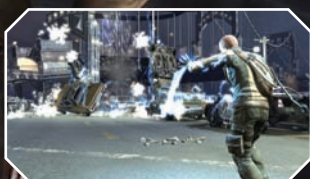
Adding another layer to InFamous is the verticality of the environment. The platforming in the game is strikingly similar to Assassin's Creed; while it is scripted to an extent, it is free-flowing and a joy to watch. And Empire City has a lot of architecture to run and jump around. Think of it as Assassin's Creed set in a modern urban environment; only more interesting and with a storyline.

The most intriguing aspect of the game, however, is the morality — you can play as either the hero, or the anti-hero, and from the looks of it, the outcome of your decisions will affect the way the game progresses. It remains to be seen if these changes are superficial or really game-changing. For instance, early on in the game you have the option to allow citizens to collect food rations provided by the gang that is running the city. You can either let them have the food or fend off defenseless citizens and keep the food to yourself. We chose to keep the food, which immediately prompted the gang's leader to put a price on our head, thus turning many of the citizens against me. The outcome may well have been different had I chosen to play nice and let the people pick up their rations. The morality system is surprisingly deep and there are various levels on either side of the scale, each affecting how the game plays out. Your moral decisions will affect you visually as well. Playing the good samaritan will show Cole as a regular everyday messenger, but steer towards the dark side and you will see his clothes ripped and covered in dust, scratches on his visibly paler face, and the electricity within him will turn from blue to red.

Sucker Punch have also put a lot of thought into the design of Empire City; not just the architecture but the way its citizens run around dazed and confused trying to make sense of what's happening around them. If you can look past the fact that the only powers Cole has is electricity, which in itself is pretty damn cool, InFamous is definitely a game to watch out for when it hits stores in June. ■

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Developer: Sucker Punch
Publisher: Sony Computer Entertainment
Genre: Action-Adventure
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Platform: PlayStation 3